

Phrasal Verbs: Metaphor & Register - Worksheet

A. Multiple meanings of phrasal verbs

- A single phrasal verb (like "get on") can have several different meanings.
- **Examples:**
 - "He **got on** the bus." -> Meaning: entered the bus. (Physical movement)
 - "Jim and Ian **get on** really well." -> Meaning: they like each other and are friendly. (Social relationship)
 - "Shh! I'm trying to **get on** with my work." -> Meaning: continue doing my work. (Continuation of an activity)
- **Key Point:** Often, there isn't an obvious logical connection between these different meanings. You simply have to learn each meaning separately.
- **Learning Tip:** The best approach is to learn and remember an example sentence for each different meaning of the phrasal verb.

B. Literal and metaphorical meaning

- **Main Idea:** Sometimes, the different meanings of a phrasal verb *are* clearly linked. This happens when one meaning is **literal** (the basic, physical, original meaning) and other meanings are **metaphorical** (figurative meanings based on an image or comparison).

- **What is a Metaphor?** It's a way of describing something by comparing it to something else that shares similar characteristics, creating a mental image.

- **Example Given ("blow up"):**

- **Literal (Basic) Meaning:** "blow up a balloon" -> inflate it with air.
- **Literal (Related) Meaning:** "blow up a building" -> make it explode.
- **Metaphorical Meaning:** "someone blows up" -> someone suddenly becomes very angry (like they 'explode' with anger, similar to a bomb or an overfilled balloon bursting). The connection is the idea of a sudden, forceful release or explosion.

- **Another Point:** Sometimes, a phrasal verb only exists in its metaphorical sense, but you can often guess the meaning by thinking about the basic meaning of the main verb (without the particle).

- **Example Given:**

- "Have we **slipped up** somewhere?" -> Meaning: "Have we made a mistake somewhere?".
- **Connection:** This clearly comes from the verb "slip" (to fall accidentally, usually on a wet or icy surface). Making a mistake is metaphorically *like* accidentally slipping. Even though you don't literally slip, the image of an accidental fall is used to describe making an unexpected error.

C. Register

- **Main Idea:** "Register" refers to the level of formality in language (formal vs. informal).

- **Phrasal Verbs and Register:** Phrasal verbs are very common and typical in **spoken English** and **informal writing** (like letters to friends, popular journalism). They are generally less common in highly formal speech or writing.
- **Formal Equivalents:** Often, there is a single-word equivalent (a non-phrasal verb) that means the same thing but is more **formal** in style.
- **Example :**
 - **"miss out** a question" (Phrasal verb, informal)
 - **"omit** a question" (Single verb, formal)
- **Geographical Variation:** Like other vocabulary, the use of some phrasal verbs can differ between geographical areas (e.g., British English, American English, Australian English).
- **Example :**
 - **"clear up** a room" (putting things away tidily) is used everywhere.
 - **"tidy up** a room" (meaning the same) is used as a synonym mainly by British and Australian speakers, less so by North Americans.

Part 1: Metaphorical Meaning

Write a metaphorical meaning of each and every phrasal verb. Then write your own sentence using the phrasal verb.

Phrasal Verb

Metaphorical
Meaning

Your Sentence

Break down

Pull through

Take off

Bring up

Put down

Look up to

Part 2: Register Awareness

Write the formal equivalent for each phrasal verb write a sentence using each version.

Phrasal Verb	Formal Equivalent	Sentence (Phrasal)	Sentence (Formal)
Find out			
Give up			
Come across			
Set up			
Turn down			
Look into			